

101 THURSDAY, MAY 10, 1956

ALONG THE SIDELINES

EDWIN POPE

Fourteen Managers for Pels' Erautt And He Liked Them All but Richards

Finally found a fellow who doesn't go for Paul Richards, the alltime Cracker managerial hero. Right here in Atlanta, too. He's Joe Erautt, the New Orleans catcher. Erautt has played for 14 managers in 14 seasons, and Richards is the only boss he just couldn't take.

"It's silly, I know," Erautt said over breakfast Thursday, "for a double-A ballplayer to put the zing on a guy who's general manager and field manager of the Baltimore Orioles. But he's the one man I never could play for."

"I'm 34, even if the book does say 31. I've been in baseball since I was 18. Of all those years, I've been in the big leagues less than two seasons. Both were the Chicago White Sox. One—1951—was under Richards."

Erautt actually winced at the memory of an afternoon in Yankee Stadium. "Richards told Marv Rothblatt . . . he pitched here last year, didn't he? . . . not to throw Hank Bauer anything slow, no matter what. Bauer came up early in the game. I signaled for a fast ball and Marv shook me off. I called for a curve and got another shake. I walked out and said, 'Marv, Richards said nothing slow for Bauer.'"

Pope

"Marv nodded. I went back and signaled for the fast one again and he shook me off again. I called for the curve, then, and he nodded."

"He wound up and came in with a CHANGE-UP . . . just about half-speed. Bauer swung and away it went."

Erautt put down his fork for a second and wagged his head unbelievably. "What did Richards do? He took me out. Me, not Rothblatt. He never even asked me what the sign was."

"I'll give Richards this: he got you in shape or killed you. He made you love baseball or hate it. I only caught 16 games for the White Sox before they traded me to Seattle in '51, but I was catching about four 'practices' a day . . . one in the morning, one before the game, warmups during the game, and more after the game. I was so tired I couldn't lift my bat, much less swing it. He made me hate it."

—A 'Yes' Made Hornsby Perfectly Happy

Erautt's list of managers is a long one—Jake Atz at Henderson, Tex., in 1940, and Winston-Salem in '41; Steve O'Neill, Beaumont, '42; Gabby Hartnett, Buffalo, and Bill Norman, Toronto, '46, after three years in service; Twitchy Dick Porter, Birmingham, '47; Jack Saltzgaver, Little Rock, '48 and '49; Jack Onslow and Red Corriden, Chicago, '50; Richards, Chicago, and Rogers Hornsby, Seattle, '51; Jack Tighe, Buffalo, '52 and '53; Skeeter Newsome, Syracuse, '54; Nick Cullop, Columbus, Ohio, '55, and now Andy Cohen at New Orleans.

"I didn't dislike Hornsby," Erautt said, "but he was a queer duck. He had two phobias: he got infuriated if you argued with him or if you told him anything was wrong with you."

"I always said 'yes' to him no matter what he said, and went ahead and did what I thought best. Long as you agreed with him, anything went."

Erautt burst into laughter and almost choked on his breakfast eggs. "I break down," he said, "every time I think about how Hornsby would come to the park at about 5 p.m., dress, and then sit there silently with his arms folded, watching the clock. When it hit 6, everybody had better be on that field."

"One night I stopped on the way out to say hi to a pal. When I got onto the field, Hornsby looked at his watch and said, 'Erautt, it's 6:01. Where the hell you been?'"

Erautt is a sort of father confessor to the younger Pelicans but he looks 10 years short of his 34 and he hustles teen-age style. He is good-natured and it may be that his idea of the perfect manager is cast in an unconscious mold of himself. Atz, Saltzgaver, O'Neill and Cohen are his favorites.

"Cohen's the greatest," he said. "How many managers you know who can really inspire pro ballplayers? Cohen does."

Yes, Erautt admitted, he has managerial ambitions himself. "Don't you think I'm getting some pretty good background for it?"